Superpowers Debate

Abi Harrison-Nye

Overview

Calling neurodivergence a 'superpower' is usually well-intentioned, but the community has mixed feelings about it. While it's great to celebrate strengths, this phrasing can create unintended barriers.

It can hide the hard parts of daily life. Focusing only on special talents risks ignoring the practical support, adjustments, and accommodations that people actually need.

This label creates intense pressure to be amazing. People can feel like they have to be a genius or extraordinary just to be accepted by those around them.

The term doesn't fit everyone's experience. Many individuals view their neurodivergence as a disability rather than a special power, so don't force the label on them.

Always let the person decide how they want to describe themselves. It's much better to compliment specific skills, such as great focus, creative thinking, and problem solving.

It's vital to offer support regardless of performance. Ensure people feel valued for who they are, even on the days when they don't feel particularly spectacular.

Useful Links

- From Deficit To Superpowers: Is It Ableist To Focus On Neurodivergent Strengths?
- Beyond Stigmas and Superpowers: A Balanced Neurodivergence Narrative
- Musing on ableism, neurodiversity, shame and superpowers